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Bill Holman

Bill Holman is one of the most respected arranger/composers in all of jazz. He was born in Olive, California on May 21, 1927, and took up the sax and clarinet in public school. After a brief fling with mechanical engineering, he established himself in the west coast jazz scene as a saxophonist and arranger. He performed with Charlie Barnet and Stan Kenton's big bands and in small groups with Shorty Rogers, Conte Candoli and Shelly Manne. Bill has worked for a long list of the best artists in jazz and popular music and has received three Grammys. He has also received honors from DownBeat *and* Jazziz *magazines. In addition to conducting master classes in arranging, he travels overseas annually, where his work is performed by radio ensembles in numerous European countries.*

Bill was interviewed in Los Angeles on February 13, 1999, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming in Los Angeles for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. And I'm very pleased to have Bill Holman with me. Welcome.

BH: Thank you, Monk.

MR: I started writing a list of the people you've arranged for and I got writer's cramp. It's really quite an amazing list of performers and bands and assignments. Did you have an inkling in your teen years that you would ever be making a career of writing?

BH: Oh I used to fantasize about it. I had a band in high school and I kind of got interested in the arranging process, but other than small town, and there were no professional musicians around there except for one guy who was a piano player and he played for ladies club meetings and things like that, and he was kind of a rake, and not too well thought of in the community. So he was our only professional, and I had no way to find out how to go about making an arrangement. I just jumped in and made an introduction to a stock arrangement one time, and that was as far as I got into it. And then I did a spell in the Navy and I was studying engineering in the Navy and I came back and went to UCLA to continue my arranging — or my engineering. Did I say I was studying arranging in the Navy?

MR: No.

BH: Engineering.

MR: Engineering in the Navy, yeah.

BH: And I went back to UCLA to continue that, and after one semester I said this is not really what I want to do. So I transferred to a music school. And I had a lot of musical material, band material and everything. Because when I was a kid the top 40 was all bands, jazz

bands and commercial bands, so I had all this stuff in my head. And after I went to the school and learned a few of the basics that had been hanging me up, I was writing charts within a month or so. So it became a reality. But getting back to your question, yeah, I did think about it but I had no idea it could ever come to pass.

MR: Well in this small town with one musician, where did you get your musical tastes from?

BH: The radio.

MR: The radio?

BH: Yeah. All day they played bands. And some good and some bad, but you get to hear everything and make your own choice, what you like. So a lot of people when they're starting out cold in music have to somehow get their own conception together without having all that background. It must be very difficult to learn the vocabulary without having heard it all before. But that end of it was pretty easy for me.

MR: Who were your favorites when you were listening to the radio? Let's say, oh 1940 and you were about 13?

BH: Oh, there were a lot. I always liked Basie's band, Benny Goodman, I was starting to get into Woody Herman, Charlie Barnet and of course Duke. I didn't understand Duke though, it was a little deep for me. Basie's old band, you know with Prez and all those guys, it was right out there. And I never lost a love for that feel, you know that really radical swinging that the Basie band did that at time. It had a small band feel almost.

MR: Curious you used the word "radical." Why would you say radical swinging?

BH: Well I just meant utmost.

MR: The epitome.

BH: Yeah.

MR: Okay. I wasn't sure what you meant by that. What about just the technical things about transposition and chord voicing and all that stuff? Did you learn some of that in college?

BH: Well when I went to this music school, those are the things that I learned, the things that I didn't have enough ambition or daring to find them out by myself, you know, when I was younger, just by trial and error, which was what a lot of the guys did.

MR: How were you able to hear what you wrote? When was the first time that you had an opportunity?

BH: When I went to that school. Because they had what they called a dance band and a studio orchestra and stuff like that, so you could hear everything that you did, which is really important. Because it doesn't do you any good to just sit home and write charts and never hear them. You don't know what works and what doesn't.

MR: I guess that was the beauty of Ellington's situation.

BH: Yeah. Next day. Well that's partly why I started my band, in the 70s. Because for years I'd been writing charts and either taking them down to a rehearsal or putting them in the mail and sending them somewhere, and never seeing the music again and not hearing it until I heard this band's particular interpretation of what I'd written. And a lot of times it wasn't exactly what I had in mind. But the simplest thing was to start my own band, which Woody Herman told me to do one time. I griped at him about a tempo and he said, "well what we tell the arrangers that are unhappy, we tell them to start their own band." So that's what I did.

MR: That must be an interesting situation. I mean by the time you finish a chart, you must know exactly, I mean you have your own conception of the tempo and the whole thing. Then to hand it over and the guy counts it off at a different tempo. And you're hoping that it works I guess, at that speed.

BH: Well usually I don't have any idea that's what they're doing until I hear it on a record or on a broadcast or hear the band in person. But it's very hard to get your conception of a piece of music across to somebody else without actually going there and doing it yourself. Because he reads it, he looks at a metronome mark, and even if he gets the mark right, the feeling might not be the same.

MR: Well it looks like one of your first assignments, with Charlie Barnet, were you still in college at that time?

BH: No. I got out of school I think about 1950, and this was '51 when I worked with Charlie. He wasn't really buying charts then but I had this chart that I wrote for him and I put it in the book and after a while I guess the guilt got to him or something and he paid me for it, but he was kind of winding his career down at that time, and he didn't want to invest a whole lot more into it. But then later in the 50s I did a couple of albums for him for the Everest label. So I got to write for him finally.

MR: Were you making more money with your instrument or more money with your pen?

BH: Well let's see. After Barnet I joined Kenton's band and I was writing for him but I wasn't writing very much. For the first nine months or so I couldn't figure out what to write for the band, so I was making more money as a player then. Then after I left him I came back to L.A. and I guess at first I was doing more playing than writing. And then gradually, after a couple of years I think, more writing.

MR: Who did you like — did you have some influences as far as jazz players that you tried to emulate?

BH: Players?

MR: Yeah.

BH: Yeah. Coleman Hawkins I think was the first one, or Lester Young I guess. Lester and Hawk about the same time, because I mentioned all those Basie records that I heard and I knew that that guy was good. Then let's see, Dexter Gordon, after I got out of the service I heard a lot of Dexter and then Al Cohn and Zoot Sims and Sonny Rollins and Coltrane I loved. I can't say he was much of an influence outside of just making me just feel good, because the way he played was not my thing naturally, but I sure appreciated him.

MR: Yeah. He always made me feel a little on edge actually.

BH: Yeah. Well I liked his earlier things, before he got into the "sheets of sound" and like that. When he would join Miles in 1955 and I heard that band, I just nearly came out of my skin.

MR: I guess so, yeah, and with Cannonball.

BH: No this was just the quintet.

MR: Pre-Cannonball.

BH: Yeah. A couple of years it was that way, and "Kind of Blue" and that stuff came out, the sextet. But Coltrane really turned everybody around in the middle 50s.

MR: How does an arranger, in his early career, get a reputation? How did you get a reputation as an accomplished writer?"

BH: Well I wrote for Stan Kenton. That's a very difficult thing now to do that, to get a reputation, because there's no bands. The only people that can afford to have bands are writers themselves, except for the commercial bands, you know, the Dorsey band and stuff like that. So there's not that opportunity to write for a band and get your stuff recorded and get a reputation that way. Well it's tough for players too because you just have to — a jazz player has to go to New York and bang his head against the wall for so many years, and maybe he'll get that reputation. Maybe not. But it's hard for writers too.

MR: Can you put into words what it was that after the nine months with Kenton, made you feel okay, now I feel I can start to write for this band? What did you need to do to match his style?

BH: Well, the thing that helped me the most was playing Gerry Mulligan. He wrote about ten charts for Kenton when I joined the band in '52, and playing those things every night was the big impetus. Because that was the first big time arrangements that I'd played. Well of course, Barnet, but I mean guys with my generation. You know Mulligan was the first guy that I got a chance to play and that was a great education. Because I could see how the things went over with Stan. Stan didn't really like a lot of them, but he liked "Youngblood" and a few others. And so in assessing what I'm going to do for Stan, I was able to see his reaction to these other things, and kind of figure well don't do that, whatever you do. Maybe this you could do.

MR: At least your chances are improving, that it won't get the ax.

BH: Yeah.

MR: What would a band like Kenton's pay for an arrangement in those days?

BH: Seventy-five bucks.

MR: Would you do these when you were on the road?

BH: Wherever. Yeah. A lot of them were on the road, a lot of them were here when we got some time off. We didn't have a whole lot of time off. When I joined the band we left for the road in March of '52 and we didn't get back 'till December. And then we went out again in January and aside for a little vacation I took in June, I guess I was home three weeks or something, the band was out until December again. So it was a full time gig. But when you're young you can take it.

MR: Were you on the band when he had the — didn't he have a string section for a while?

BH: Yeah. I think they called that the "Innovations in Modern Jazz" or something, so they called it the Innovations Orchestra. That was, he did two tours with that, I think in '48 and '49. That was before me. Then in 1951, at the end of 1951, a lot of people left, Bob Cooper and Bud Shank and Shelly Manne and Shorty Rogers, a lot of the stars left. So when he reorganized the band in early '52 that's when I joined. But no strings.

MR: He certainly generates discussion about where he fits in jazz history. How do you feel about his place?

BH: Well there's a definite place there. I don't know, not being a historian it would be hard to say where it fits but he did a lot of things, he gave opportunities to a whole lot of people that were able to go on their own and have good careers. A lot of his music, well I liked very much. Well the late 40s, the thing Rugulo was selling. I liked those a lot at the time. Then later in the 50s, when I was into it I liked more swinging things. So that's why I wasn't able to write for him for a while, because I didn't want to write things like Pete was doing, I didn't know how, and I knew Stan didn't want Count Basie charts so I was trying to find a middle groove there. But at the time that I joined in fact Gene Roland got me an interview with Stan on the strength of something I'd done in school which was a twelve tone blues and very contrapuntal and all that, and Roland said, "my God, this is what Stan is looking for."

MR: It sounds like right up his alley.

BH: Oh you know him?

MR: Twelve tone blues.

BH: Oh. I think everybody writes a twelve tone blues at some point. Leonard Feather did it. So it turns out Stan was looking for a contrapuntal kind of approach and that was what I

was doing. So we had a connection right away. I just had to figure out how to make it work.

MR: When you write a chart, let's take that one for example, can you hear that thing in your head pretty much complete?

BH: The row?

MR: The arrangement as a whole.

BH: Oh. Well you hope so. I'm sure when I wrote that I didn't hear it because that's something you learn over time, how to hear the thing. A lot of times when you're a student you're just doing things and say well I'll see if this work, or what's this going to sound like. Hopefully you know what the chart's going to sound like, unless you're trying something new and then you just hope it works. And sometimes you get surprised and something sounds different from what you imagined it and you say well okay. You have to decide whether it's okay or not.

MR: Are there a couple of Kenton arrangements that you feel stand out as your most successful?

BH: I did one on "Stella By Starlight" that featured Charlie Mariano on alto sax, and that came off very well, and I also did around the same time, this was 1955, I did one on "Stompin' at the Savoy," which has kind of stood up. We still play it with my band now. So I think those two stand out to me.

MR: I have a couple of things that I wanted to play for you. Actually I think it's a bit early for that, because I wanted to ask about the first time — you had quite a list of singers here that you arranged for also. And when was your first experience doing a chart for a singer?

BH: It must have been around the middle 50s for Peggy Lee. I believe in starting at the top you know.

MR: I guess so.

BH: And I was really scared because I had kind of a crush on her since 1942.

MR: Oh that's nice.

BH: But she's a great singer, so I really took it easy writing the charts. I didn't put a whole lot in there, you know, afraid to get in their way. She told me later after a couple of years, she said, "the thing I really like about your charts is all the stuff you leave out." So I guessed right on that one.

MR: There's a lesson there. Rests are good.

BH: Yeah.

MR: Peggy Lee, Buddy Rich, Sarah Vaughan, Anita O'Day. Quite a long list here. And all this time you're playing also, playing in the different bands?

BH: Yeah. I stopped doing studio work in the early 60s when all the commercial people started requiring saxophone players to play flute, and since I was writing and everything I figured I didn't really want to take time to learn to play the flute, so that kind of went down. And then in the 60s I had some surgery on my jaw and my lip, they cut some nerves and my lip lost its strength, so I just quit playing then for about 15 years until I started my band again, and then I wanted to be able to participate, so I got the horn out and it kind of worked. The lip had come back somewhat so I was able to play a little bit. And a few years later I had some dental implants put in and they blew the nerves again, so currently I don't have a whole lot of strength in my lip, but I'm working on it because I still want to be able to participate with the band.

MR: Now leading and organizing a big band has got to be quite time consuming I would think. Do you have a corps of guys that you can count on to be at a certain place at a certain time?

BH: Yeah, the whole band does that. It took a few years to get it established but now all the guys, if they can't make a rehearsal they send their own subs, they call their subs and I don't have to call an hour before the rehearsal trying to find a trumpet player or something.

MR: Oh, that's good.

BH: So it kind of runs by itself now, but it took — the first few years was really hairy. Because guys would call up at the last minute, "oh I can't make it." But it was all that, the visions of doing all the phoning and the organizing and finding a place to rehearse that kept me from doing it before. But a friend of mine talked to a club owner, the friend is Don Piestrup, he's a writer too. He talked to the owner of Donte's out in North Hollywood and said, "Why don't you get Bill a Sunday night, every Sunday night with the band. And he had a copyist who would work very inexpensively, so they kind of laid this band on me and after a while the club gig vanished, but we decided we'd keep the band going anyway. And we made a few records and we've done some good gigs, so it's been a good time.

MR: Yeah, 1960, "Bill Holman's Great Big Band." Was "Big Band In Jazz Orbit" '58, was that one of your first records under your own name?

BH: That was the second one. Well I did an octet record for that "Kenton Presents" series in 1954, but that was the second big band thing. I did one for a company called Coral, which was a subsidiary of Decca in 1956 or 7, '57 I guess. And Orbit was '58 and the "Great Big Band" was 1960.

MR: Did you do much writing for the studios as far as the film music and—

BH: I did some in the '50s when they were using a lot of jazz scores, and especially a lot of T.V. shows. I worked with Leith Stevens on a couple of things, who was a very good Hollywood picture film composer. I've never gone into actually composing for movies. I did a couple of grade C movies in the '50s.

MR: Grade C huh?

BH: Yeah.

MR: Did you ever see them?

BH: Yes. One of them made T.V. and it comes out occasionally as a rerun.

MR: Can you tell me what it is?

BH: It was called "Swamp Women."

MR: "Swamp Women" with score by Bill Holman. Yeah?

BH: Yeah. Terrible music.

MR: I'm going to watch it.

BH: I don't think they even play it on T.V. anymore. Then the other one never even made it to T.V.

MR: Well what kind of instructions did you get with a film like that? What do they give to you?

BH: Well how this first film came together was a theater, a guy in the south had owned a string of theaters and had a bunch of color footage of the Florida everglades, real nice pictures. And he brought them out here and asked Roger Gorman if he could make a film around this footage, you know, get a story written and everything, just so this guy could use it. And it did. It was about a gang of girl jewel thieves that had escaped from prison and go back to reclaim their swag, their buried treasure. And they had to go into the everglades, and they'd do some of them, then they would shoot some of this scenery, so and part of it took place in Mardi Gras in New Orleans, so it had to have a Dixieland, part of it had to be Dixieland, part of it had to be kind of big band, and part of it had to be spooky, everglade music. So that was the only instruction I got. It turned out I wrote about a half hour too much music because the director wasn't there to spot it with me. I spotted it with the music editor, and so it's part of the learning process.

MR: Can you recall what you got paid for that?

BH: Eight hundred bucks.

MR: All right. I guess you can. Let me play a little piece here. This is kind of going backwards chronologically I think for some of the music you've done over the years.

[audio interlude]

MR: Whose idea was it to go to The Beatles for a tune?

BH: It was mine. That tune had been in my head for a long time and I said someday I'm going to make a chart on that and finally I just got around to doing it. I did it in one night because I'd been thinking about it so long that I had things kind of worked out in my head. And I was afraid Buddy wasn't going to like it because he wasn't a big fan of rock. And he flipped over it, and he made it into a very hot piece.

MR: Yeah. And not that many things in his repertory were in sixes or threes either. Maybe he really enjoyed playing that groove.

BH: I'm sure he did from the way he played on it. He sailed into it.

MR: Can you recall what you got paid for that chart?

BH: No. Well I think at that time it was around three fifty or something like that.

MR: I'm just curious as to how those kind of things work, if you're contracted out. Have you had an occasion where, not including your own band, where a band leader would call you and say, "I want something original, something that no one else is going to have right now." And how do you price those kinds of projects?

BH: Well it depends on who you're working for, for one thing. If it's a pop act that's one thing, if it's a jazz guy it's another thing. If it's a record company paying for it that's another thing. So there are several different things that go into it, plus your own price, you know what you're able to get for them. And it's always less than it should be, but you take all those considerations and you give them a price. Then he says something like, "oh that's great, I was afraid it was going to be more."

MR: "Oh that's not what I meant, that was just the first alto part."

BH: Yeah.

MR: That's tough.

BH: Mostly it's, "oh I can't afford that."

MR: Yeah, right. Well this particular thing I think goes back quite a ways.

[audio interlude]

MR: Ringing any—

BH: No. I figure I wrote it but I don't know what it is. I did a lot of charts in the '50s during the west coast jazz, because people would have an artist they wanted to record, they said okay we'll do it on such-and-such a day, call an arranger. And so you'd write four tunes and there were so many of them that it all kind of runs together.

MR: Yeah. Well this is called "Zig Zag" and it was on an album that I found with a lot of different people, but it was under your name, it said Bill Holman and "Zig Zag." Actually the album, I'll show it to you later. I think there was an alto player and yourself on it.

[audio interlude]

MR: Do you have that record over there, Tim? It's got those saxophones all over it.

BH: It sounds like Charlie Mariano and Sam Noto. I hope I don't play at this tempo.

MR: I think you do, actually. That's it. Here we go. It could be that you've never even seen it before.

BH: Well it was probably under somebody else's name that I did it and they just changed it to me. Because I remember every record I did.

MR: Does this sound like you?

BH: Yeah.

MR: You know to me when I listen to a few things you did, it really sounded like I could tell you are an arranger.

BH: What do you mean by that?

MR: I can hear you playing like lines and then repeating them and variations that I don't — maybe it's after the fact you know, but that you may think of certain melodic things, having spent so much time writing them that they come out in your playing too.

BH: Uh huh. Possible.

MR: Well that's just an opinion.

BH: Yeah, okay.

MR: It must have been — in '76 you did some writing for Zoot Sims?

BH: Yeah.

MR: Was that enjoyable?

BH: Yeah. Well he was one of my dear friends after we were on Kenton's band together and I really worshipped his playing a long time before then, but we got a chance to hang out, we drove in the same car on the road, and it was just really nice to get to know him. So I'd always wanted to be able to record something with him and I never thought how it could happen, because people have a tendency to wait for people to call them for a project or something. So I finally decided well maybe I can get this project going myself, so I asked Zoot and he said sure, and I called up Norman Granz and I said, "Norman, I always wanted to do something with Zoot Sims," you know, with the band. So I was thinking of a big band but Norman said we'll have a smaller band, ten or twelve pieces. And that's how that came about. And I was really happy to be able to do that and to finally get to work with my old pal.

MR: "Hawthorne Nights." Is that the name of it?

BH: Yeah. Hawthorne is a suburb of L.A. and that's where Zoot grew up so that was the romantic, "Hawthorne Nights."

MR: Tell me, the term "cool jazz" to kind of switch subjects, is supposedly a west coast thing. Do you feel that there is a style of west coast playing that is different than the east?

BH: Yeah. Mostly I think it's because of the people that are here, not because there's anything in the water or anything that makes it that way. But most jazz players go to New York because that's the place for a jazz player to make it. Mainly players come to L.A. to work in the studios, whether they're actually able to do it or not, but that's the motivation for a lot of players being here. And there's a lot of guys that play in the studios that can play good jazz too, but they're not jazz players. That isn't what they do for a living. And there's a difference there. Of course that cool thing in the 50s has kind of generated itself because after Mulligan started his quartet and he had a kind of a cool approach to that, and I don't know who started the word "cool," I was on the road at that time with Kenton for the first two years of that. But when I came back to town I found that "cool" was the operative word and counterpoint was the next operative word, the record producers found out about counterpoint because somebody told them that's what Mulligan was doing with the quartet.

MR: Oh, okay.

BH: So they said, "well we're going to do this record with so-and-so and I would like you to write the music and try to do some counterpuntal things."

MR: They've got a music word to use and make it cool at the same time.

BH: Yeah. And then guys were starting to write Bach type fugues and calling it jazz, just because it was counterpuntal and it got to be ridiculous. The thing that disturbed me about that scene the most was they'd decide to record a guy, and they'd hire an outside arranger to write the music. The arranger brings the music in to the date and that's the first time that the artist has seen the music. You know it has nothing to do with him except there are spots in it for him to play. Now most of the guys that record do their own music, which I think is a much healthier thing.

MR: Right. Because otherwise it's a pretty contrived situation, they're trying to second-guess what's going to sell.

BH: Well and the guy can't play his best, because he's just learning the music. He's reading chords off of a sheet of music instead of hearing it, which if you write the thing yourself or you play it on the gig for a few months then you can play jazz on it. But just looking at a chart you can construct a beautiful solo if you're that good at reading charts, but it could be much better if you're hearing it. Too much emphasis on eyes in music anyways, and not enough on the ears, especially in the jazz education thing. They're educating these thousands of kids every year and most of it they learn by eye. I don't know what to do about it because it's like we said before, the chance to learn on the job, where you learn to hear things, doesn't exist anymore so it's hard. So it's hard. I learned how to play jazz at jam sessions.

MR: A good statement.

BH: Yeah.

MR: Jazz has been kind of elevated in one sense to a pretty, art form, but I'm not sure that — the opportunities for it are not rising with that.

BH: No they're not. Nobody knows what happens to all those guys that take jazz education. Some of them become teachers, a few of them become professionals, but there's a whole lot that don't.

MR: Tell me how the recording with Natalie Cole came about. Gee, almost eight, nine years ago?

BH: Well the producer, who was her husband at the time, just called me and said come out to the studio where I'm working and we'll talk about it. So we talked and he wanted to know about some players to use and talked to me about the music. They were mostly — oh yeah, that was the Nat Cole album, and they were things that Nat had done. So it turns out what he wanted for — I think he wanted me to do four charts — were almost copies of the charts that Nat had done. In fact one of them was almost the chart that Billy May had written for Nat, it was almost note for note, in like a slightly different key that I did it for Natalie. Then there were two others in that first album that David Foster called me to do, and he just said go ahead, you've got it, which naturally are a little more fun. But I really enjoyed getting to know her and getting to hear her. I think she's really a good singer. She's got a little jazz feel with a little of that Dinah Washington stuff in there.

MR: Were you in on the recording sessions?

BH: Yes. Yeah, I conducted the band.

MR: Thanks for saying that, because that was something I meant to ask about, is that not all arrangers must be great or capable conductors. How did you learn to conduct? Was it something you did in school also?

BH: Well things that are in tempo, dance band or jazz band charts, the conducting is kind of a grand word for it, because what you do is get them started and get them stopped. And you kind of give a little bit of shading if they need some help, but supposedly all the dynamics are marked on the page and good studio players are very good at picking up stuff like that. So unless you've got something that's out of tempo or with strings or something, there's not much to it. I did learn to conduct strings in the late 60s. I was doing some what they call "sweetening" for pop records. I worked with The Association and The Fifth Dimension and Diana Ross, and I got to work with strings. That was the first chance that I'd worked a lot with strings. I'd done some with Peggy Lee but a very little bit. So that kind of got me into that.

MR: If you were writing a chart, or a string chart for The Fifth Dimension, did you get a recording of the tune that was like the rhythm track or something?

BH: Yeah.

MR: So to have the vocals on it?

BH: Yeah.

MR: Okay, so that you knew pretty much where your spots were?

BH: Yeah. That's the whole idea of doing it that way. Because in pop music the record producer wants to have control over everything. That's how they do it.

MR: Can strings swing?

BH: Well I would say not usually but there is, the Metropole Orchestra in Holland, I don't know if you've heard of them.

MR: Metropole? Yes.

BH: Yeah. They've got a string section, it's a fairly good size, it's almost 30 strings, and they're very enthusiastic and very cooperative. Most string players don't want to hear about playing jazz. They don't even like contemporary classical music. But these guys can actually swing a little bit. They can do two types the [scats] kind of swing, and the straight-eighth thing, which is a very subtle thing that a lot of horn players are not familiar with. But these guys do it and they volunteer to do it. Because I had one thing that I just, I didn't tell them it should be a jazz feel, I just told them to play it straight and this and that, and one of them said, "well you know we could swing this a little bit if you wanted it." I said, "sure" and it worked great. But that's the only — well some of the, was it the Kronos Quartet that did the Monk things? They got a good feel.

MR: Yeah. Turtle Island also. They swing pretty good. But you said something about straight eighth notes. How do you mean that? I assume that that is slightly different from Mozart eighth notes.

BH: Yeah. Well I usually consider real straight eighth notes as rock & roll [scats] that's very strict. But there's a way, like you've got a rhythm section that's playing a triplet feel [scats] a horn line could go [scats]. It's not quite straight but it's not a triplet feel either. And unless you were raised with it, like I was, it's a very hard thing to pick up. And these guys can do it.

MR: That's good. Because it makes for some nice contrast if the rhythm section is swinging and they're almost — it's great.

BH: Yeah.

MR: You've had quite a list of Grammy nominations here. Are you surprised sometimes when you get a nomination for a particular arrangement that maybe if you had said, in the last

year of the things I've arranged, I would have picked this one, and that's not what they picked?

BH: Yeah, some of them. But you don't argue.

MR: Best Jazz Arranger in *Jazz Times* in 1990, '95, '98, and '98 in *Down Beat* too. Do you feel like you have to change your style to — I hate to use the term keep up with the times, because you obviously have. Is there a conscious effort on your part to put things into your arrangement that reflect other music that's going on?

BH: Oh I use quotes sometimes but they're usually quotes of older things. I don't keep up with the times so much as I keep up with myself. You know because you're always progressing, you're trying to learn new things, and you don't want to do the same thing you were doing 20 years ago, and so that's kind of what drives me to do different kinds of things. There isn't much going on that I would want to use except other jazz writers, and why do that? I mean I'm too old to be going around being influenced by everybody, I did that.

MR: You've become the influencer.

BH: Maybe.

MR: I think so. So the days of stealing something from Manny Albam or something like that—

BH: Odd you should mention that, because I did that exact thing. When he was writing for Barnet in 1949 I heard them down in Balboa and they played that, what do you call it, "Swell and Super" a thing, a take off on "Keen and Peachy" that Shorty had done for Woody. And I went home and tried to write a chart something like that. But yeah, that's what you do when you're young. You try this and you hear something you like and you say I want to try that. And then it just kind of gets absorbed into the whole conception and it doesn't exist anymore in its original form but it's there some way.

MR: In your own band, I'm not sure how to ask this question, has electronics entered into, even in the big band field. Actually what I think I'm getting at is does your rhythm section use electric instruments and if so does it change the sound?

BH: No we don't use them. We use an amp on the bass, but that's — no, in the jazz world there hasn't been a whole lot of that, in the straight ahead jazz, the mainstream. Brookmeyer has used synthesizers to really good effect on some of the things that he's done in Europe. But mostly for a straight ahead jazz band, an electric sound doesn't fit. It doesn't have that grease that you like to say that humans have.

MR: Any rock or popular music that's come by your ears in the last 20 or so years that you really like?

BH: Well I've got to mention The Band. My favorite rock band, with the great flavor they had to their music. And I like the Rolling Stones too. Did you say jazz bands?

MR: Well I was thinking of rock first.

BH: Yeah. Well I mentioned those two. And then there's some other people that are more blues people, like Bonnie Raitt, I like her, and the more blues-oriented people mostly I like. Because that's kind of a common connection with jazz.

MR: How about jazz people?

BH: So many.

MR: What's that?

BH: So many. Well Joe Lovano is one, in fact I'm going to be doing a project with him later this year.

MR: What size ensemble?

BH: A small band, eight, ten pieces something like that.

MR: Do you ever know beforehand who else you're writing for?

BH: In the group?

MR: Yeah.

BH: Sometimes they tell me. Sometimes if it's a band you know who's there. But a lot of times you don't know.

MR: Is there a danger in writing something that you say boy I know this fellow's going to be on the date and that he will play this great, but down the road someone else is going to be playing that thing.

BH: It happens. It doesn't sound the way you thought it was going to.

MR: But it sounded darn good the first time, didn't it?

BH: Well who knows, maybe this new guy puts a good spin on it.

MR: That's true. So let's say there's a young man who comes to you and says I really want to get into the field of writing for jazz bands and so forth. Is there any kind of advice you can give to that person?

BH: Well I usually tell them to get a band together, first thing, and start writing and start listening to your charts and you can get kind of a local reputation doing that you know, if the band starts to sound good or your music starts to sound good. I don't know, guys ask me mostly about getting work in Europe and I just say well make a tape, make a cassette and start sending it out to these producers around there that work in the radio stations where they have bands. They still have staff bands at these radio networks like they used to have here. And like this network in Cologne that I work for, they have a jazz band, they've got a full symphony, they have a pop symphony which is smaller, you know 60 pieces, but the full symphony is over a hundred I guess, and these people get paid every week.

MR: How do they do that? Is it government sponsored?

BH: Yeah. And the people pay a tax on the radios and on their T.V.s and they support it.

MR: I see. Wow. So you go over there almost every year?

BH: Yeah. I've been doing it since 1980. And the bands are folding up slowly. Like the world is turning into the U.S.A. They're finding better things to do with their money than have bands. I used to work in Zurich, they had a band there, I worked a couple of times with that, that's gone. And there used to be a band in Holland that I'd work for every time I went over there, they had a Monday night gig at a club which was broadcast. And that got done away with. And in Scandinavia, Sweden used to have a band that's gone now. And Finland, I was just there in November, they had a radio band which is now freelance, and they work for the radio sometimes, but mostly they're working for the government doing concerts, and they're sponsored by the government now. Denmark still has a very good radio band, but this Metropole, the group that the Metropole belongs to, they have also a full symphony and an 80-voice choir plus this 60-piece Metropole band, and it's also a steady gig, every day.

MR: What does the musician's union do for you as an arranger? Do they set rates for arrangements or anything like that?

BH: Yeah. They have scales for everything. Usually after you get a reputation or something you get over scale. But they have a scale for recording, which is kind of a minimum. You can't really work for less than that but you can work for more. And the recording and film things, everything that's electronic they stick to the scale pretty closely I mean as far as not letting you work for less. On the live performance and everything it's much hazier because there's a lot of people that can't afford to pay scale so some guys will work cheaper. But it's actually supposed to be a minimum.

MR: Do you have a basement full of scores?

BH: Yes. I have a whole house full. Scores and CDs are going to run me out of my house.

MR: I'm wondering if you've been able to keep the original scores of most of the work you've done.

BH: Up until about 1970, very few of them because before then they weren't able to Xerox the oversized sheets, so you'd write a chart and you'd just give it to the band leader and that's the last you'd see. Now I make a Xerox of everything before I give it to the employer, whoever it was, so I have most everything. I've got some of the older things, the things that I recorded myself. I'm trying to find some of the things that I wrote for Charlie Barnet for those two albums we did. I'm trying to locate those with the thought of maybe getting published. So I talked to a guy who knows a guy who knows where they are and he sent me a list and there's quite a few of the scores in there that I hadn't seen for 30 years.

MR: Who owns them?

BH: Well I guess Barnet's estate, but they gave part of them to a school and they gave — I think some of the others were just in Charlie's house and they gave them to this guy to go back, and he lives in Philadelphia, and he's going to get them in shape again and he's going to put them in a collection somewhere.

MR: Okay, here's a hard question. Have you ever had an occasion where you wrote something that came out just really badly, and the person you wrote it for said, "hey, no thanks, this doesn't work at all"?

BH: Yeah, yeah. It was for a singer. I think they heard the thing that The Fifth Dimension did, "Aquarius," and they wanted a feeling like that. And they wanted it for an opener, and I did what I thought was it, and they took it on the road someplace. I don't know how these other players played it, again, my not being there to explain it might have made the difference, but they said it was a total egg.

MR: So are you responsible for the age of "Aquarius," the [scats] all that introduction stuff in that chart?

BH: Yeah.

MR: Nice stuff.

BH: Uh huh.

MR: Who's the fellow? Bones Howe?

BH: Yeah.

MR: Was he the guy? Was he easy to get along with? Was he a good producer for you?

BH: Yeah. He came on the scene in the 50s when the west coast jazz thing was going along. I mean he was such a good mixer, he hadn't had enough work yet to be accepted into the union, so the union didn't want him to be a mixer. They actually didn't want him at the board and all the musicians insisted on it so they finally gave him some kind of an internship or something like that, where he was able to do that. And then he turns around to be a hot pop producer.

MR: He had the ears then.

BH: Yeah.

MR: Well this has really been interesting to hear from the side of the guy who puts it all down on paper. I really appreciate you joining me. And I look at this list of people you've written for, it's like a legacy. I think putting music down on paper is really a great thing to leave, not just the recordings of it.

BH: Yeah it's always going to be there, but a lot of those people are gone. It's probably never going to be performed again but I really feel blessed in being able to do that for a living. How much better does it get? I sit there at my piano thinking this is what I do for a living.

MR: From a guy from a town that had one musician of questionable character.

BH: Yeah.

MR: You did pretty well.

BH: Yeah. Thank you.

MR: And I'm sure you have some great pieces of paper coming in the future too. What's your next project? You have something with Joe Lovano?

BH: Yeah, that'll probably be in the fall. I'm going to do a thing with the Metropole again in September, and with that radio network in Cologne I think in November, and we've got a few gigs with the band. We're working on a summer tour in Europe for some of the festivals over there.

MR: Oh great.

BH: So that should really be a trip. See it's a kick for me to — we did a two night, three night thing in Vienna a couple of years ago and to see these guys in a foreign country was really a trip for me, you know, to see them down there even practiced in this foreign hotel, and watching them cope with all this stuff. So that's going to be fun. A friend of mine is having his 80th birthday celebration over in England in April and about half of the band is coming over for that, and we'll do a little band concert and then with a few English guys do a big band concert. And we've got a gig in Salt Lake City in May. We don't work around here much.

MR: Yeah, you've got to leave town.

BH: It's like I was telling Buddy before, that I don't work much around here, much of my work is someplace else.

MR: Well the guys in New York say the same thing.

BH: Yeah?

MR: Yeah. There's not much. They go there, get established, and then they leave to work.

BH: Well with all the jazz players in New York, they would have to be 500 jazz clubs for them to all get jazz gigs there.

MR: Right. And there's certainly not that. Well thanks for your time today.

BH: My pleasure.

MR: It's been a real pleasure, and I appreciate it.

BH: Yeah.